

OpenClaw System Prompts

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1. Course Content

Course Overview

- 💡 OpenClaw adopts an innovative **"file-as-prompt"** architecture - the AI Agent's behavior, identity, memory, tool usage rules, etc., are all defined and loaded through multiple Markdown files in the workspace.

2. 📁 Switch Workspace

- OpenClaw's system prompts and skills are stored in the workspace path: `$HOME/.openclaw/workspace`
- The orinnano mainboard comes pre-configured with different workspace content in Chinese and English. The content meanings are the same, only differing in language
- Users in different regions can switch the language of OpenClaw workspace documents according to their needs
- Chinese workspace (prompts and skills content in Chinese)

```
cd /home/jetson/Language
sudo cp -a workspace_zh/. ~/.openclaw/workspace/
```

- English workspace (prompts and skills content in English)

```
cd /home/jetson/Language
sudo cp -a workspace_en/. ~/.openclaw/workspace/
```

- After configuration is complete, restart the OpenClaw gateway to apply the configuration

```
openclaw gateway restart
```

⚠️ **Warning**

- The `.workspace_en` and `.workspace_zh` hidden folders under the `$HOME/.openclaw/workspace` path are Chinese and English template files. It is recommended not to modify them

3. AGENTS.md

- Function Description

AGENTS.md defines the top-level specification of how the Agent operates in the workspace.  It can be understood as the Agent's **"user manual"** - telling the Agent how to start, how to manage memory, what things can be done, and what things are absolutely forbidden

- Content Structure

AGENTS.md mainly contains the following core sections:

Section	Function Description
First Run	Guide the Agent's initialization process on first startup (read BOOTSTRAP.md)
Mechanical Body	Describe the Agent's physical carrier (robotic arm, chassis, camera) and control methods
Session Startup	Specify the startup process and file reading order for each session
Memory System	Define the layered architecture of daily records and long-term memory
Red Line Rules	List absolutely forbidden behaviors (destructive commands, modifying robot program code)
Operating Specifications	Distinguish between freely executable operations and operations requiring prior inquiry
Memory Maintenance	Memory organization and update mechanisms during heartbeat

 Note

 The factory AGENTS.md prompt restricts OpenClaw from modifying robot program code

4. SOUL.md

- Function Description

SOUL.md is the Agent's **"soul" and core** . It defines the Agent's thinking methods and behavioral guidelines when facing tasks - how to control the robot body, how to find and use skills, how to plan and execute actions, and under what circumstances it should pause or refuse to execute. SOUL.md shapes the Agent's core behavioral pattern as a "robot operator".

- Working Principle

SOUL.md is read by the Agent at session startup as the underlying guiding principle for task execution. It does not specify specific skill parameters, but rather specifies **what kind of thinking process the Agent should use when encountering any task**. For example, the Agent is forced to check the skill library before any task begins, and cannot execute directly based on intuition or memory - this "check documentation first then act"

habit is defined by SOUL.md.

5. IDENTITY.md

- Function Description

IDENTITY.md defines the AI Agent's **self-awareness and personality traits**. It defines who the Agent "is" - its name, personality, language style, and basic identity positioning. This file gives the Agent a consistent personality when interacting with users.

- Working Principle

At each session startup, the Agent reads IDENTITY.md to establish "self-awareness". This information affects the Agent's tone when answering questions, the way it proactively offers help, and the style of building relationships with users. For example, an Agent set to be "friendly and gentle" will naturally use more approachable language when replying to users.

6. HEARTBEAT.md

- Function Description

HEARTBEAT.md is the configuration file that controls the **heartbeat detection mechanism** in OpenClaw . The heartbeat mechanism allows the Agent to periodically "wake up" to perform background checks and maintenance tasks without the user actively initiating a session. This is similar to a robot's automatic scheduled inspection - the Agent can silently complete memory organization, status checks, and other work in the background.

- Working Principle

The OpenClaw gateway periodically checks the content of the HEARTBEAT.md file to determine whether it needs to trigger the Agent's heartbeat API call:

- **File is empty or contains only comments:** Skip heartbeat call, Agent will not be awakened in the background

Note

 In the robot's factory configuration, the heartbeat mechanism is disabled by default.

7. TOOLS.md

- Function Description

TOOLS.md is the Agent's **tool usage localization notes** . In the OpenClaw system, "Skills" define the general working methods of tools, while TOOLS.md records the Agent's own specific configurations and personalized settings. Simply put: Skills are manuals (general), TOOLS.md is your personal notes (unique).

- Working Principle

During a session, the Agent will read both the relevant Skills documentation to understand the general usage of tools and TOOLS.md to obtain specific configurations related to its own deployment environment.

8. 👤 USER.md

- Function Description

USER.md is the exclusive file used by the Agent to **understand and remember user information**. If IDENTITY.md is the window for the Agent to understand "who I am", then USER.md is the window for the Agent to understand "who you're dealing with". It records the user's basic information, preferences, project background, and other contextual information, helping the Agent provide more personalized and thoughtful services.

- Working Principle

At each session startup, the Agent reads USER.md according to the process specified in AGENTS.md. Through this file, the Agent can:

- Know how to address the user (name, form of address)
- Understand the user's timezone, preferences, and other background information
- Remember things the user cares about and ongoing projects

9. 🧠 MEMORY.md

- Function Description

MEMORY.md is the AI Agent's **long-term memory file** 📁. In OpenClaw's memory system, there are two levels of memory storage:

1. 📅 **Daily Records** (`memory/YYYY-MM-DD.md`): Record original events and conversation logs that occur each day, similar to human "diaries"
2. 📁 **Long-term Memory** (`MEMORY.md`): Essential information extracted from daily records, similar to human "long-term memory" - containing important events, learned experiences, key decisions, and insights

- Working Principle

The loading and usage of MEMORY.md follows these rules:

- **Only loaded in main sessions:** When the user directly converses with the Agent, the Agent reads MEMORY.md to obtain long-term memory
- **Maintained autonomously by the Agent:** The Agent can freely read, edit, and update MEMORY.md in the main session

Note

In actual user usage, you can:

- ✎ **Actively write important information:** Write content you think the Agent should remember long-term directly into MEMORY.md
- 🕒 **Observe Agent's autonomous maintenance:** After the Agent runs for a period of time, view the content automatically accumulated in MEMORY.md
- 🔄 **Manage memory content:** Regularly check and organize MEMORY.md, remove outdated

information, ensure long-term memory remains refined and accurate